

Raid Farms: A Symbol of Resistance

What went wrong with Raid Farms?

Raid Farms has been very rightly criticised for its lack of player interactions, anarchic nature, and being overly restrictive in its rules and changes to the vanilla game. For the players of Raid Farms, the changes that led to the server's failing are a major failing on PineconeLP's part, and a lesson that he could (and should) learn here on out. I have constantly called Pinecone out on his organisation and establishment of the server, including the inherent incompatibility between anarchy and player interaction in an SMP server. Raid Farms been sitting at 5-10 players for weeks, even months now, and the server environment could not feel more deserted and lonelier; something that was meant to be solved by Pinecone's wheat currency and world border, among other additions.

Although this cannot be said for its players, the outside observer actually could gain a lot from this shitshow of an experiment. I'm not talking about the theories that can be developed from the server's hilarious failure, but the experience one could have roaming and exploring the server's ghost towns and uninhabited buildings. No, this is not unique to Raid Farms at all, nor is it an isolated case of an abandoned server, but a glimpse into the lore, history, and past players that once existed there.

The spawn square

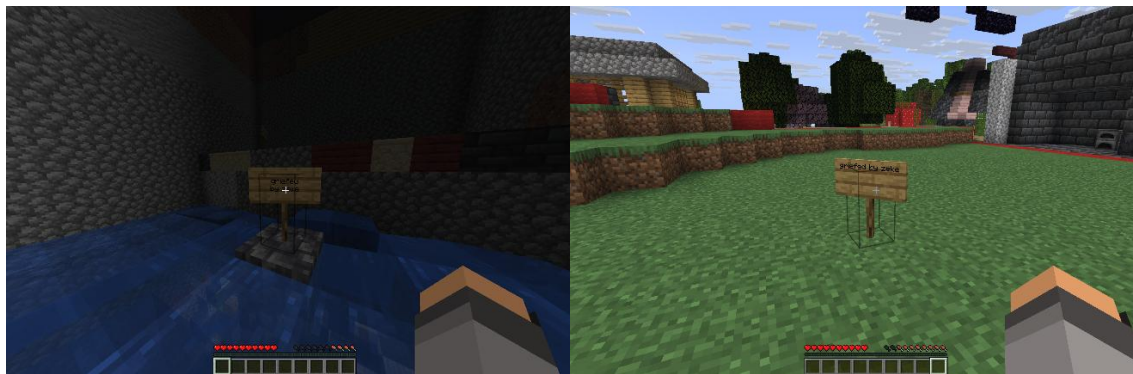
Most new players' experience of Raid Farms would be its spawn area – the 100 by 100 metre square that serves as the centre of the server, houses shop and studio-apartment plots, and has a quaint lake where players can fish. The square also has PvP protection and is the only area in the entire world where griefing is banned, which explains why immediately outside the square massive, towering cobblestone structures loom over you.



^(Left) Looking up from the studio apartment plots, of which a singular one is claimed, a gigantic tower composing of cobblestone, various wood planks, and snow(?) I know if this was in my back garden, I would not buy that house. Massive eyesore that is.

^(Right) Swimming to the top of one of many floating water columns, one could grab a more expansive glimpse of the grieving that happened here. The obsidian tower is not just an obsidian tower, but a symbol of what happens when you allow players to grief wherever they want.

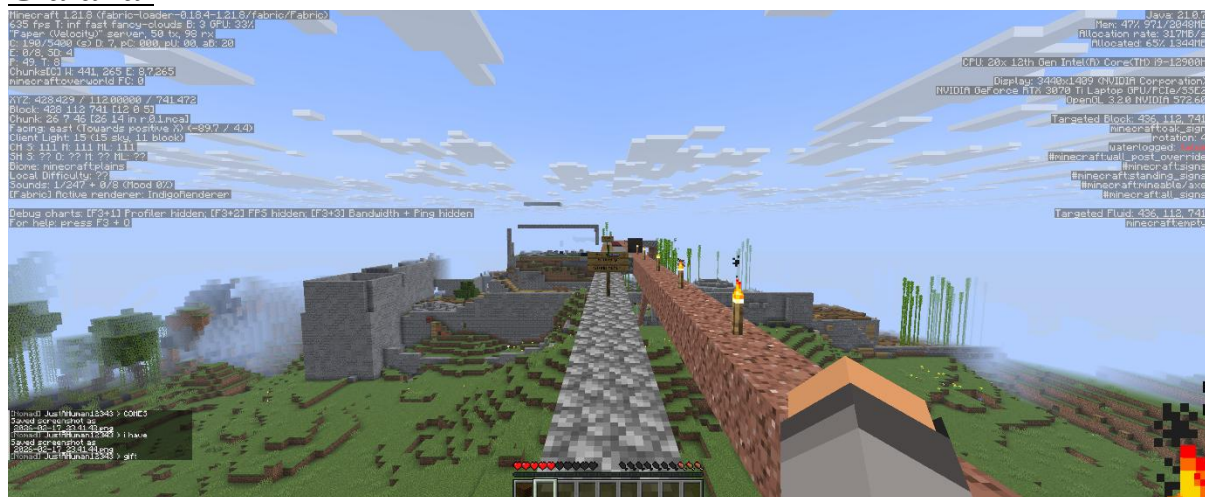
Those structures aren't just an eyesore, but almost as if they were spikes around a radioactive site warning players to not go any further. These are quite important monuments and landmarks for the existing server members and long-time players, so there's no doubt these jarring constructions give the server and its members a sense of identity. With any longstanding building that is obscure or abnormal, they can help shape a place's culture and sense of being, which I would say these spires do.



Venturing out, in, or under the spawn square will cause your eyes to catch on quite an inconspicuous sign, with the words “griefed by zeke” on it. The sign is always (from what I’ve seen) an oak sign, and is placed near a griefed area, the act presumably done by a player called *zeke*. Looking in the Raid Farms Discord server, the player referenced is most probably *Zekethegameboy*.

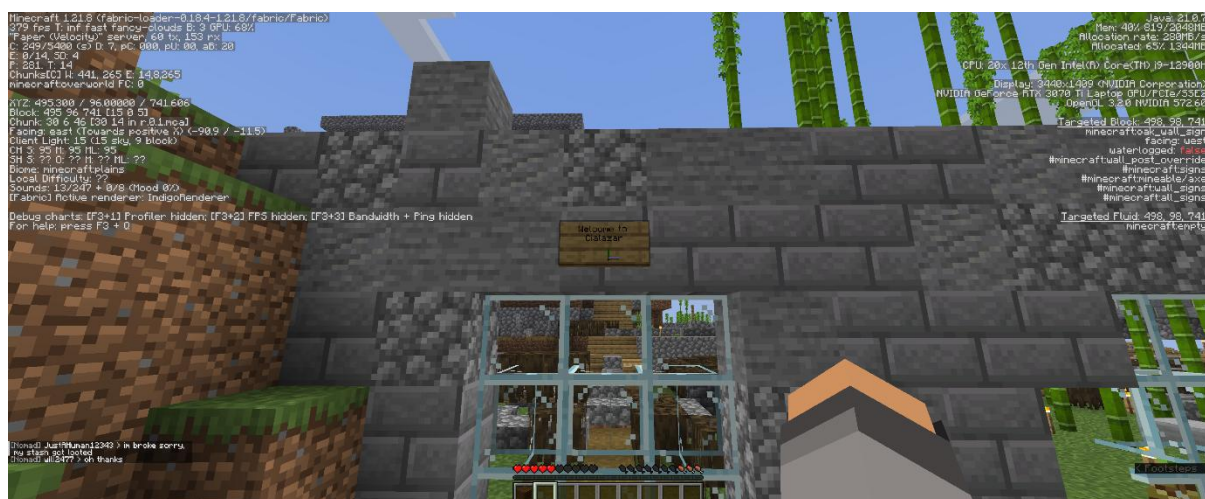
Again, this is really alienating and confusing for me as a new player, and causes me to question if these griefs destroyed anyone’s builds that they spent time and effort in. This is a fascinating case of a kind of entrance barrier to Raid Farms. New joiners have to first ignore the barren, war-like landscape around the spawn area, brave the landscape that looks like the trenches of WWI, and travel hundreds upon hundreds of blocks to find an untouched, peaceful area where they can settle and set their roots. If one has successfully done this, they must still protect their land against the occasional horseback traveller kitted out in extravagant trimmed diamond armour and enchanted bows. Most would simply leave after seeing the lawlessness of the landscape, and the rest would fall to their demise in one of the many random pits around the square.

Cialazar



To the four cardinal directions around the square, there are many bridged made from cheap, easy-to-find materials running in parallel with each other, seemingly leading nowhere. However, if you were to traverse these floating super-highways, you would find yourself in one of many abandoned fortresses, which one could only imagine was once massively populated and its shops bustling with players. The day I made the (very stupid) decision to sprint out on one of the many bridges was the day I realised Raid Farms was not the barren, unpopulated, lonely server I thought it was.

It still is barren, unpopulated, and lonely, but when I saw this (the picture above), my Minecraft body filled with excitement. My *real* hands were beginning to tremble as I slowly walk (as I had no food) towards to massive compound, begging me to not fall off the bridge for some idiotic reason.



Once you arrive, (which I will come to discover is common practice in these satellite communities) you are greeted with a sign which shows the city's name – this one was called *Cialazar*, apparently named after its founder, *Ciala*, according to *Ob1cloney1234*.

Looking in the Discord server again, the first mention of it seems to be by someone named *Pudd* in the #general chat on the 14th of November last year. Similarly, the same player with the tag *PuddPuddofMaja* was also the first to say the city's name in the Minecraft chat, pointing another player to its very own Discord server, on the 18th of November 2025.

This is just one small part of the very fascinating lore and story of this specific town, and of course there are numerous more dotted around the world. The abandoned ghost city is also referred to as *Ctown*, which is most likely a portmanteau of *Cialazar* and *town*.



Inside the city's walls, there were unmanaged stalks of bamboo reaching up to twenty or thirty blocks tall, evident of the city's age and its history. The unmanaged, wild, overgrown bamboo made me feel like I was wading through unmanaged fields in the English countryside, with bees, mosquitos, and flies all swarming around me as I explored around. The mildly grieved ground also mimicked that unmanaged countryside look; the imperfection and ruggedness gave the city character and tells its once vibrant community's story. I can only ever speculate and imagine in my very own head what the town would've been like, as I do not have a time machine, nor a veteran contact with whom I can interview, but I think the thought experiment makes us all historians and archaeologists trying to interpret a cave painting from two millennia ago, and that's pretty cool, don't you think?



Archaeologists usually struggle with the purposes of items in ancient civilisations, famously when obscure objects are labelled as “objects used ceremoniously/for rituals,” but what I found was nothing like that.

In the middle of the city, there is a random spiral staircase that (now) has no signage or indication as to what it leads to or is. It has deepslate slab steps and is decorated with pale oak slabs on the outer wall, which I thought resembled a pair of doors. Diorite bricks and glass panes border the inside wall and prevent miners from falling in the central shaft. Torches were also randomly placed around the staircase with no system or pattern.

I could say that there were deeper cultural and historical meanings and uses of this mysterious and obscure structure, but unlike your English teacher, I wouldn't go there. If I were to interpret other uses of a staircase leading to a mineshaft, the heat death of the universe would come before I thought of something; However, sometimes it's good to simplify and just accept that what's before your eyes is just cool.



^ Another chemistry nerd spotted



^ Underground chests were a cheap and efficient way to protect your property from raiders and griefers

Before I move on to the next town, let me introduce you to one of many buried chests I found on my travels. No, not the kind on beaches. The kind found inside the ground as a storage method away from enemy griefers!

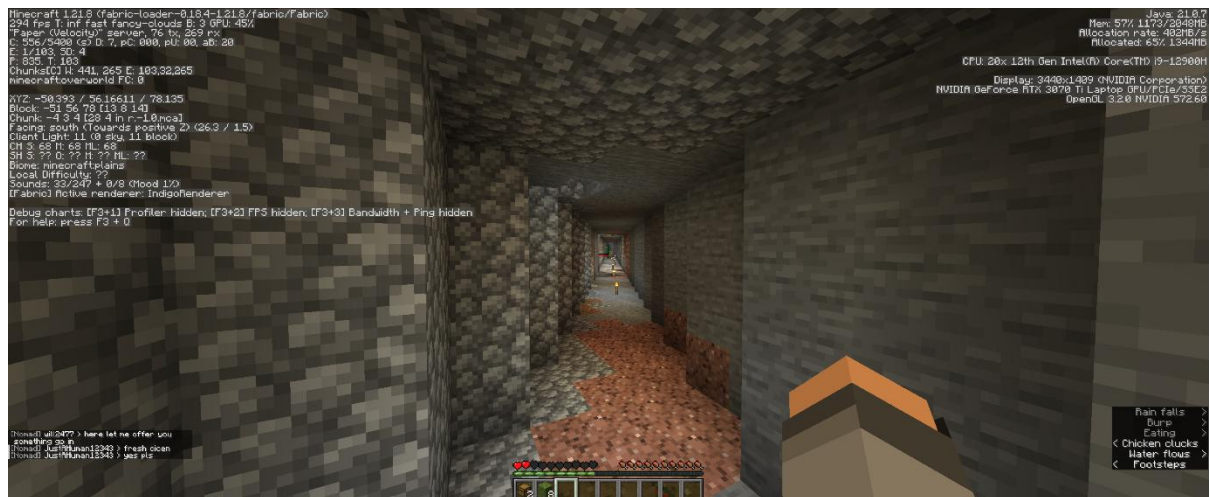
These kinds of chests are a direct result of anarchic server design with unrestricted griefing and PvP, forcing less equipped players to essentially have to hide from other players in order to survive. This is no way to operate a city, no less a server.

Players should have *some* levels of basic protection from hostility and unwanted fighting. Real life could be mimicked here, where those who do harm are heavily punished (within the system), for example a heavy fine or ban from a city, to make these violent incidents exceedingly rare.

Travelling!

I got killed at *Cialazar* by a skeleton with an enchanted bow, and that's all I'll say. I'll go out next time with a weapon and a shield, at least.

This time, I opted to go the opposite way from the spawn square. The savannah was more peaceful and looked less grieved than other parts of the server, although it still *very much* was. I came across another tunnel/covered bridge that could only exist in the context of an anarchic server.



The diagonal passageway reminded me of foot tunnels under rumble tube tracks in London, loosely put together, filthy everywhere, and littered with masses of cigarette butts and random splashes of paint. The imperfectness of this tunnel describes Raid Farms as a server very well. It embodies the spirit of anarchy in all its forms – carelessness, disorder, and chaos. The seemingly random cobblestone lining the walls in a carved underground tunnel don't make any sense, but is probably a repair after a big grief.

The tunnel runs under a mangrove swamp that's extremely waterlogged, muddy, and full of vines that would catch any player trying to sprint jump. It was constructed out of desperation for a lack of options for efficient transportation. The desire to leave the hellscape that is the spawn square had to be fulfilled, and the one-hundred-block-long tunnel was the escape route to peaceful wilderness. This kind of construction could not be possible if not for the server promoting itself as an anarchy server and encouraging player freedom.

Then I saw a diner or bed and breakfast of some sort, hidden in the middle of the swampy jungle, made of mangrove and oak planks and some snazzy diorite skirting. What was significant about this build was how close it was from spawn. Just 360 blocks out, the inn was actually very well-preserved and actually had some hints of a recognisable structure.



^ This building had a restaurant/diner on the bottom, with hotel rooms or some kind of flats above, something very common in UK high streets! (v below)



I doubt that any of these rooms would have actually been used, but I'm sure of the fact that some players still unknowingly have their spawn set here from when they just started out playing. This building also had a surprising lack of signs, which I've been using as my main gauge for the community "utility" of a structure.

The more signs a place has, the more people visited it and found a sense of comfort and belonging, leading them to place a sign to mark their presence in the very rare communal spaces around the map. The "X was here" signs really allow players to not just be a random person, a meaningless entity in the server, but is the only way (in Raid Farm's anarchic server) for its members to share a moment – and most importantly, a space.

I talked about this in my recent video (not sure how recent this article will be when it's published!) where I explain the effects and mechanisms of healthy and harmful interactions, but I wanted to also point out the *indirect* interactions a server's environment can provide and do upon a player. The signs are exactly this – and for the sake of not repeating myself, you should know exactly why they provide health interactions at this point.

The Compound

The last structure I went to was called The Compound – a small, rectangular, cobblestone structure, with a wheat farm in the middle. There are some chests and barrels dotted around the farm too for storing wheat seeds but looking into them yielded nothing.

The wheat farm being at The Compound's very centre shows how a server's mechanisms influences player behaviour greatly. If it was not for wheat's "value" as a currency (even though it failed, and players did not like it, more on this in the next section), the people who built this rudimentary building introducing new players would not have a wheat farm as its welcome. This speaks to the actual consequence and effect of the wheat currency, which is as a social glue. In a server that has no real, effective mechanism to draw players into a central, communal area, something else must shape their identity.

You might even be able to draw comparisons between minority diaspora communities with Raid Farms players – groups of people who cannot interact or share experiences together through some kind of systemic oppression or force, and must use rare, hard to find, community spaces where they can interact without outside intervention attempting to pull them apart. Truthfully, the cohesion that Raid Farms players have and showed when Pinecone announced the server's closure was evident – they were never enemies or hostile to each other, but the system in which they live in created the environment where they are not able to interact freely with each other, and even if they were, it was not something that Raid Farms *actively* encouraged.

De jure anarchy servers with a *de facto* SMP playerbase (survival Minecraft players who want to interact with other players and share builds) will always create a stark divide between the system's expected outcome and the players' inherent assumed outcomes on that server. Raid Farms' mechanisms *allowed* its landscape to be grieved, which caused players to spread out because of that fact. However, players have always secretly been yearning for interactions, for community, for someone to play *with*, and this was evident by the masses of screenshots people shared on the Discord server for everyone to reminisce on the systemic oppression of the people's will for community.



^ The entrance to The Compound. A sign says “a kind place for newbies” next to the door. Not sure how “kind” it is if it’s griefed all around inside, surely doesn’t send the best message now, does it?

v The self-proclaimed “kind” space! (Some creative liberties were used by the journalist in question, which is not representative of the writer, who is not the same person)



And this is where my journey ended, until I finally decided to commit to Raid Farms and got myself some gear and found some diamonds. Along the way, of course, I found out even more about Raid Farms’ culture. However, this will be a discussion at a later date.

An upload of all the photos in this article is available here:

<https://github.com/Minecraft-Server-Theory-Institute/workspace/tree/2341c8933769bb4a7e6e27cfb867ac459d7b268f/Raid%20Farms%20A%20symbol%20of%20resistance>